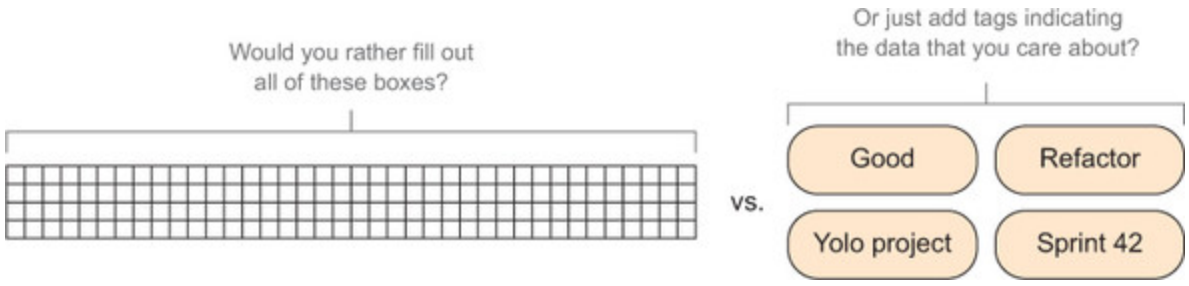
The alternative to adding tags in most systems is creating custom fields. This is the equivalent of adding columns to a flat database table; the more fields you add, the more unwieldy it becomes to work with. Teams are forced into using the structure that exists, which may not translate into how they work. When new people join the team or when new efforts spin up, it becomes cumbersome to add all the data required in the system just to create tasks. This is visualized in figure 3.7.

Figure 3.7. The difference between organizing flat project data and adding relevant metadata with tags



Adding data in the form of tags allows you to add the data you need when you need it and allows you to return to tasks once they're complete to add any kind of data you want to report on. This is valuable because it helps you figure out what works well for your team even if it's contrary to normal trends. For example, the number of comments on a ticket could mean that your team is communicating well, but it could also mean that the original requirements were very poor and they were flushed out through comments on the card. By going back and marking cards as "worked well" or "train wreck," for example, you can find trends that may not have been visible before.

In addition to the other good reasons for using tags, this method of organizing your tasks allows you to sort, aggregate, or map-reduce your data much easier. Instead of modifying queries and domain objects to get good analysis, you can simply add more tags, and you'll be able to see clear trends in your data, as you'll see later in this chapter.

Some PTSs like JIRA support tags or labels and have explicit fields for them. In JIRA the data comes back in a format that's nice and easy to work,